India’s economy and its military spending are dwarfed by those of China. China’s military capabilities have increased rapidly since the late 1990s. From 2009 to 2018, China’s military expenditures grew 83 percent, whereas India’s grew only 29 percent.[72] In fact, the power gap between China and India has widened to such an extent that it is legitimate to ask if the contest between these two major countries really ought to be called a rivalry.

Nonetheless, even if China in 2018 possessed the world’s second-largest military force in terms of expenditure, India was ranked fourth, and in terms of purchasing power parity, India’s economy also ranks as the fourth largest in the world. Therefore, while the power gap between India and China has widened, India’s resources have been increasing. Within India’s neighbourhood in the South Asia and Indian Ocean Region, India clearly views China as a rival for influence over strategic spaces of vital importance to India. With new resources, India’s willingness and ability to engage in its own neighbourhood have increased. Hence, due to China’s increased presence in this region and India’s growing resources, Sino–Indian rivalry in the South Asia and Indian Ocean Region is now actually more prominent than at any point since the Cold War – despite the widening power gap.[73] In the following, I explore how this rivalry plays out in terms of the Modi government’s concerns and responses to China’s growing footprint in South Asia and in the maritime domain.

India–China rivalry in South Asia

China’s growing presence in Pakistan, Myanmar, and other nations in India’s neighbourhood has been called geo-positional balancing.[74] China is seen as positioning itself in the geographical space on the subcontinent in the same